

Uncaria rhynchophylla (Rubiaceae) Gou Teng

Description Climbing perennial growing to 33 ft (10 m). Has opposite lance-shaped leaves, thorns, and composite flowerheads.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China and Southeast Asia, *gou teng* is cultivated in the southern and eastern provinces of China. The stems and thorns are collected in autumn and winter.

Parts Used Stems, thorns.

Constituents *Gou teng* contains indole alkaloids, flavonoids, triterpenoid, and polysaccharides.

History & Folklore The first recorded use of *gou teng* in Chinese medicine is in the *Miscellaneous Records* (c. 500 CE).

Medicinal Actions & Uses *Gou teng* is a sedative and antispasmodic, and is mainly used to ease symptoms such as tremors, seizure, spasms, headache, and dizziness. It is also prescribed for infantile convulsions. In Chinese herbal medicine it "extinguishes [internal] wind [gas] and stops tremors." It is also used by the Chinese to reduce high blood pressure and excess liver "fire."

Research Chinese tests on laboratory animals indicate that *gou teng* lowers blood pressure, reduces anxiety, and has notable sedative activity.

Related Species Like *gou teng*, pale catechu (*U. gambier*) contains a constituent that lowers blood pressure. See also cat's claw (*U. tomentosa*, following entry).

⚠ **Caution** Take *gou teng* only under professional supervision.

Uncaria tomentosa (Rubiaceae) Cat's Claw, Una de Gato

Description Climbing vine growing to 100 ft (30 m) or more, with stems up to 8 in (20 cm) in diameter, large, glossy leaves, and sharp hooks (the "cat's claws").

Habitat & Cultivation A native of tropical rainforests in the central and eastern Andes, especially Peru, Ecuador, and Colombia, cat's claw has also been found in Guatemala, Costa Rica, and Panama. Until recently, the root bark was the part most commonly used as medicine. However, by the early 1990s collection from the wild threatened the species' survival. Only the stem bark, from ecologically sustainable sources, should be used.

Parts Used Stem bark.

Constituents Cat's claw contains pentacyclic oxindole alkaloids (POA), tetracyclic oxindole alkaloids (TOA) in one chemotype only, triterpenoid glycosides, sterols, flavonoids, and tannins, including epicatechin and proanthocyanidins.

History & Folklore Known by the Ashaninka and other indigenous peoples of central Peru for its power in regulating illness, cat's claw has been used since the earliest times to treat serious illness, from asthma and diabetes to arthritis and cancer. Native healers are able to distinguish between what are botanically identical plants, selecting those that have a low TOA content and are therefore most likely to prove effective in strengthening immunity.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Like echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92), with which it combines effectively, cat's claw supports a weakened immune system, and can reinvigorate the body's efforts to counter infection and inflammation. The herb's antioxidant activity also helps to contain the widespread cellular damage that occurs in chronic degenerative disease.

Conditions that may benefit include infections such as chronic fatigue syndrome and HIV/AIDS; chronic inflammatory diseases such as rheumatoid arthritis and ulcerative colitis; and asthma. Cat's claw may also be taken to help prevent cancer, particularly breast cancer, and is useful in countering the damaging effects of chemotherapy.

Research Investigations into the root and stem bark have established that cat's claw has potent anti-inflammatory, antioxidant and immune-stimulant activity. The POAs and water extracts of the bark stimulate production of white blood cells and nonspecific immune resistance, and appear to inhibit tumor development and growth; extracts of the bark are strongly anti-inflammatory and may inhibit inflammatory gene expression. Nevertheless, the bark's medicinal activity probably results from the synergistic effect of several compounds, including the tannins. Clinical research in Peru indicates that cat's claw may have use in the treatment for HIV and AIDS. Of the two types of cat's claw, only the one containing POAs should be used as medicine, since the TOAs may suppress immune function. Cat's claw has a contraceptive activity. A small-scale clinical trial in Brazil found that patients with advanced cancer had more energy and some improvement in quality of life when taking a cat's claw extract.

Caution Avoid taking Cat's Claw during pregnancy and while breastfeeding.

Urginea maritima syn. *Drimia maritima* (Liliaceae) Squill

Description Perennial growing to 5 ft (1.5m) from a large white or red bulb. Has a single flowering stem, a rosette of large basal leaves, and a dense spike of white flowers.

Squill contains substances that have a strongly tonic effect on the heart.



Habitat & Cultivation

Native to southern Spain, the Canary Islands, and South Africa, squill is cultivated in the Mediterranean region. The bulb of the white (but not the red) variety is unearthed in late summer.

Part Used Bulb.

Constituents Squill contains cardiac glycosides (0.15–2.4% bufadienolides, including scillaren A), flavonoids, stigmasterol anthocyanidins, and mucilage. The cardiac glycosides are strongly diuretic and relatively quick-acting. They do not have the same cumulative effect as those present in foxglove (*Digitalis purpurea*, p. 202).

History & Folklore Squill appears in the Egyptian Ebers papyrus (c. 1500 BCE). In Greece it was used by Pythagoras and Hippocrates in the 6th and 5th centuries BCE.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Squill is a diuretic, emetic, cardiotonic, and expectorant plant that finds use in a wide range of conditions. It makes a good diuretic in cases of water retention. Since its active constituents do not accumulate to a great degree within the body, it is a potential substitute for foxglove in aiding a failing heart. At low dosage, squill is an effective expectorant. At higher doses, the herb acts as an emetic. Squill is also used in homeopathic preparations.

⚠ **Caution** Use only under professional supervision. Squill is toxic in excessive doses.

Vaccinium macrocarpon (Ericaceae) Cranberry

Description Small, slender, evergreen shrub, growing to 1 ft (30 cm), with oval, dark green leaves, pink flowers, and round or slightly pear-shaped red berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to eastern North America and northern Asia, cranberry